

Pollution

The growing human population is producing more and more waste, ranging from sewage to spent radioactive fuel. Dealing with all this waste is a huge problem. Much of it is just dumped, buried, pumped into the atmosphere, or poured into rivers and oceans. The resulting pollution is inflicting terrible damage on nature—and on our health.

▼ BLIGHTED BEACH

Goats, cats, and birds scavenge for edible scraps among the plastic garbage swept onto this North African beach by the waves.



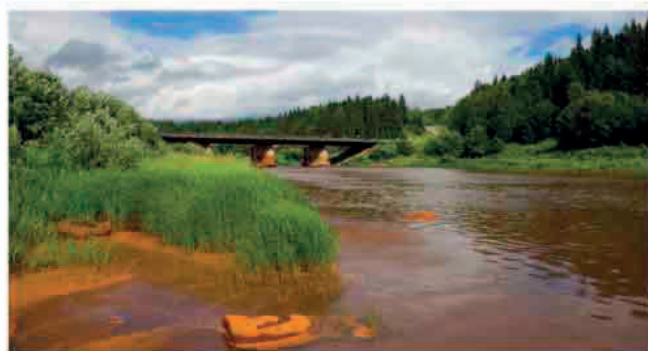
DEADLY FILTH

Over much of the world, untreated sewage from badly drained towns pours into rivers and seas, causing water pollution that spreads disease. It also upsets the balance of nature by making the water too rich in plant nutrients. This can encourage the explosive growth of toxic algae that kill other organisms such as these fish.



GARBAGE

Until the mid-20th century, most of the waste we produced was buried and slowly decayed. But most modern plastics are almost indestructible by any natural process, so they pile up in great multicolored heaps of garbage. Much of it ends up in the oceans, where it kills wildlife.



TOXIC WASTE

Industries such as mining, papermaking, and chemical manufacturing produce poisonous wastes. These are often released into rivers, killing everything farther downstream. The wildlife may recover from one accidental spill, but industries that routinely release toxic waste can poison entire river systems.